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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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DOJ faces audit over Epstein release

Watchdog will probe whether agency followed the law in sharing files

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK
AND MAEGAN VAZQUEZ

The Justice Department's chief watchdog said Thursday that his office is launching an audit of the department's compliance with the law compelling the release of millions of pages of investigative material tied to sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

The internal probe, announced by Deputy Inspector General William M. Blier, follows months of complaints from victims who say their personal information was included in publicly released documents and from lawmakers who have questioned decisions to redact the names of members of Epstein's influential circle from some of the files.

The review will focus on how the Justice Department identified the more than 3 million documents it has made public since late last year, the guidelines used to determine what information to redact or hold back, and how officials have addressed concerns raised over the disclosures in the months since.

"If circumstances warrant, the OIG will consider addressing other issues that may arise during the course of the audit," the inspector general's office said in a statement. It said the office will issue a report at the end of its inquiry, summarizing its investigators' findings.

The audit's announcement is one of the most high-profile actions taken by the Justice Department's inspector general since the start of President Donald

SEE EPSTEIN ON A4



MARK SCHIEFELBEIN/AP

President Donald Trump speaks in the Oval Office on Thursday flanked by several top members of his administration.

Lebanon looks to Trump for 'leverage over Israel'

As talks resume, 10-day ceasefire will be extended 3 weeks, president says

BY ELLEN FRANCIS

PARIS — Heading into a second round of rare direct talks with Israel, Lebanon is urging the Trump administration to pressure Israel to scale back its demands and end its military invasion of the country, Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam said in an interview with The Washington Post.

Days after the Israeli army published a map showing off the strip of southern Lebanon it says

it seized as a buffer zone against Hezbollah attacks — Salam said Lebanon could not sign any agreement that does not include a "full withdrawal" of Israeli forces.

"We cannot live with a so-called buffer zone," he said, "an Israeli presence where Lebanese displaced people are not allowed to return, where destroyed villages and towns cannot be rebuilt."

In Paris, the prime minister had called for extending a shaky ceasefire brokered by the United States, following the example of President Donald Trump, who has extended the ceasefire between the United States and Iran.

On Thursday, during the second round of peace talks at the White House, Trump announced that the 10-day ceasefire will be

extended for three weeks.

It was the first time in decades that Lebanese and Israeli officials bargained directly in a U.S. bid toward potentially normalizing relations, which Hezbollah has long rejected.

Israel has said the ceasefire, which includes provisions in its favor, will not stop its military operations to devastate Hezbollah, the Iranian-backed militant group in Lebanon.

Beirut, meanwhile, hopes that the extension of the ceasefire will eventually secure an Israeli military withdrawal and allow more than a million displaced people to return home. Some have already ventured back to the south, but Israel has warned residents not to cross into the Lebanese villages it now controls.

The 72-year-old prime minister, who is a former president of the International Court of Justice in The Hague, said the U.S. role as a mediator is crucial.

"We are entering these negotiations convened by the U.S. convinced that the U.S. is the party that can have leverage over Israel," Salam said Wednesday. "Their role was critical in reaching the ceasefire, and we hope they will continue exercising their leverage over Israel."

In recent days, however, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said his forces created a "buffer zone" about 10 kilometers deep into Lebanon, giving no indication that Israel would be willing to step back from hard-line demands to occupy swaths of

SEE LEBANON ON A13

Unflattering secrets exposed in tech titans' bitter legal feud

Filings have revealed cringey texts, emails or private diaries of Musk, Altman and other VIPs

BY SHIRA OVIDE
AND GERRIT DE VYNCK

Tesla chief executive Elon Musk and Sam Altman, CEO of ChatGPT-maker OpenAI, are scheduled to face off in court next week in a case brought by Musk that claims Altman and others enriched themselves by allegedly betraying the artificial intelligence company's founding mission.

The bitter legal feud between the two tech titans is prying open the industry's most powerful circles by spilling the tea of Silicon Valley VIPs.

Hundreds of court filings have revealed cringey texts, emails or private diary entries of Musk, Altman, other OpenAI founders and other public figures. They include Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg privately offering to use his social platforms to help Musk's interests, Musk insulting Amazon Executive Chairman Jeff Bezos (twice) and a journal in which a big MAGA donor muses about becoming a billionaire, according to the filings. (Bezos owns The Washington Post; OpenAI has a content partnership with The Post.)

SEE FEUD ON A4



EMMA KUMER, DEMETRIUS FREEMAN AND JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST; ISTOCK



KIRBY LEE/IMAGN IMAGES

Fans pose in Pittsburgh, where the mayor said: "This week is 99 percent about selling our city."

NFL Draft is Pittsburgh's moment

City canceled schools as part of plan to host event bringing fans, hope

BY TIM CRAIG

PITTSBURGH — The school day was starting, but Arnetta Fuqua decided to let her 7-year-old daughter sleep a bit longer.

It was a sunny-enough Wednesday in April, but Ralilah, a first-grader in Pittsburgh public school, would be studying from home through the end of the week, after school leaders decided to shutter classrooms — not for snow or heat or a global pandemic, but for the arrival of a new kind of marquee sports event: the NFL draft.

Fuqua had just unpacked a grocery delivery from Walmart. She thought Ralilah could do her lessons later in the day without logging on to her laptop. But around 9 a.m., she reent the packet that Ralilah's teacher had sent home and realized they had to log in to record attendance and complete some initial lessons.

Pittsburgh's time in the national spotlight was turning into a stressor well known for sending parents into tailspins.

"I can't log in to the computer," Fuqua, 33, said,

SEE DRAFT ON A10

Political bets' perils are revealed in Kalshi cases

Candidates banned from prediction market after wagering on own races

BY PRAVEENA
SOMASUNDARAM

Mark Moran, a former contestant on the reality TV show "FBoy Island," mused online in late 2024: Wouldn't it be funny if he challenged a geriatric congressman?

Eventually, he placed bets that he would run for office — a decision that is only now landing him in hot water for political insider trading and exposing how prediction markets are monetizing much of daily life to absurd degrees.

As Moran's political ambitions grew from a social media joke into something a sliver more serious, the self-described disenchanted former Wall Street worker said he reached out to an employee of the prediction market platform Kalshi. Moran asked to be added to a market in November where traders were betting on "Who will run for public office next year?" He'd already told the New York Post that he was considering a run,

SEE KALSHI ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Medical marijuana reclassified The drug will now be listed on Schedule III, similar to some common prescription painkillers. The order does not decriminalize recreational use. A6

A kraken-like octopus Scientists say the colossal beasts hunted the Late Cretaceous depths, competing with apex predators. A6

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